

The dark web

As the dark web isn't regulated a visitor's computer has a higher risk of catching viruses and malware. Scams and botnets are also common. While visiting a criminal website isn't an offence, making a purchase on one is illegal. In short, the dark web isn't a safe place you want to visit. However, there are important uses for the dark web, especially in countries with government-restricted internet access.

People hiding from authorities

Activists and persecuted minorities can use the dark web to organize support without being traced by people or organizations that could potentially do them harm.

Selling money

Criminals who produce counterfeit (fake) money often use the anonymity of the dark web to find customers.

Human trafficking

The practice of kidnapping people and selling them through the dark web is increasing. Criminals also use the dark web to sell human body organs, which is illegal in most of the world.

Whistleblowers

A whistleblower is someone who leaks confidential secrets about an organization because they believe some of its activities are illegal or immoral. Without anonymity, whistleblowers would immediately be arrested.

Drugs

The sale of illegal drugs makes up the majority of dark web transactions. For this reason, police authorities target dark web marketplaces to shut them down.

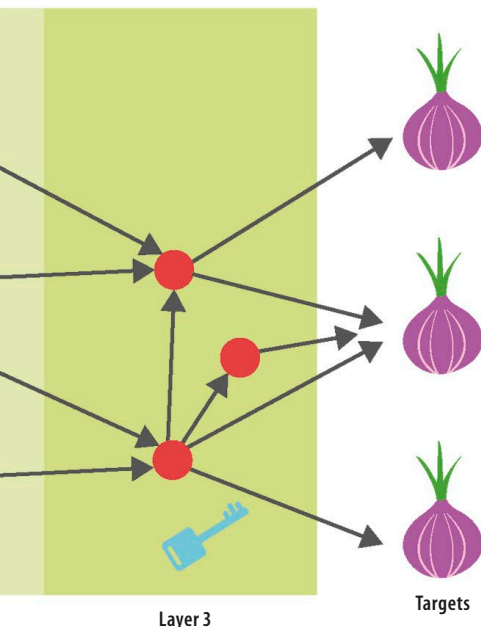
Weapons

Though the web weapons trade is relatively small, illegal weapons in the wrong hands can do a lot of damage.

◁ Complicated routing

The browser sends the onion to its target device via multiple nodes. Each node can only decrypt one layer. Since none of the nodes know both the source and the target destination, they can't tell who is talking to whom, but the message is compiled at the other end.

Transactions on the dark web are usually conducted in bitcoin – a new digital currency.



IN DEPTH

Pros and cons of the deep web

Pros

- Protects against data harvesting and data theft.
- Helps protect people who really need anonymity, such as activists and whistleblowers.

Cons

- Extra security precautions make Tor a lot slower than other browsers.
- Tor requires large volumes of traffic. If only one person uses the network it's obvious which data is theirs.
- Traditional onion routing has no encryption on its last leg.